

The EU's new migration pitch

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Presented by Altana By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Welcome to SOTEU week! Let's get started. START HERE: Sweden's election was too

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Welcome to SOTEU week! Let's get started.

START HERE: Sweden's election was too close to call last night , with Magdalena Andersson's center-left bloc holding a lead of just one seat over Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson's right-wing alliance after most results had been declared, Tim Ross reports.

Exit polls gave the center-left a clear lead, but official projections later showed the race narrowing dramatically. The final outcome may not be known until Wednesday. Stay tuned.

In today's Playbook:

- What are EU leaders doing in Santa Claus' hometown? Playbook has the details.
- A sneak peek at new proposals to improve labor mobility inside the EU.
- Faces in the crowd: Ursula von der Leyen, Manfred Weber, Mark Carney, António Costa, Jozef Síkela, Petteri Orpo, Friedrich Merz, Mette Frederiksen, Janez Janša and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick explain why centrists are betting on a tougher migration stance to fight elections — and how Brussels plans to help them.

****A message from Altana:** Altana is the AI network where businesses, logistics providers, and governments are rearchitecting global trade. With Altana, businesses can prove compliance before goods ship and build more efficient, resilient, and secure supply chains. Logistics providers can automate the full brokerage workflow, and governments can promote economic security, manage borders, and enable the flow of trusted trade.**

DRIVING THE DAY

BRUSSELS TAKES ON "WEAPONIZED" MIGRATION: The European Commission is weighing legal measures to help EU countries respond faster to sudden arrivals of large numbers of migrants, including

coordinated returns of groups of people, three EU officials and diplomats told Playbook.

The plans, which could be trailed in Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union speech Wednesday, are a response not just to the crisis in the Spanish exclave of Ceuta but also recent cases of deliberate or "weaponized" migration into Baltic states via Belarus, the officials said.

The push is part of a broader Commission effort to show that it's tightening control over irregular migration as right-wing parties gain ground. The Berlaymont points to falling asylum numbers, a beefed-up EU border force and fast-tracked talks on boosting the EU's partnership with Morocco.

Von der Leyen floated the "one grouped return" initiative at a lunch with EU ambassadors on Friday and received "generally positive vibes" from the room, per one diplomat, granted anonymity to speak frankly about the confidential meeting.

The Commission would provide legal guidance on when countries could temporarily suspend asylum applications in certain circumstances. "We can provide the legal texts and interpretations, but the member states decide what they want to do," an EU official said.

But there's a legal risk: The diplomat warned the plan could become a "legal nightmare" if it breached the principle of "non-refoulement" — the rule barring states from sending people to places where they could face serious harm.

The EU official said countries could invoke the Geneva Convention, which allows states to protect their borders from "invasion," adding "there are court cases ongoing in Lithuania on this point."

Von der Leyen is also expected to cite falling asylum applications, promote deals with non-EU countries and revive calls to triple the staff of the EU's border agency, Frontex, the diplomats said.

Here again, there could be opposition: "Von der Leyen floated to basically expand the border force to 30,000," added the diplomat cited above. "There's quite a lot of skepticism about this ... You'd have to pull people off national border forces."

Amid the tub-thumping, the EU's Dublin system risks breaking down, a second diplomat warned. The rules generally make the country of first entry responsible for an asylum claim — and require it to take back applicants who move elsewhere. The diplomat accused Italy of flouting them. "A lot of people are very concerned."

The bottom line: Though asylum numbers are down, the political pressure on migration is still sky-high. "We have to be clear that migration is still a top issue for people," European People's Party chief Manfred Weber said in a statement ahead of the speech.

BIG AND BREAKING

THE EU'S CANADIAN GOODIE-BAG: Officials are weighing how to pull Canada closer into Brussels' economic and security orbit ahead of Mark Carney's arrival as a guest at this year's SOTEU, Playbook's Max Grier, Gabriel Gavin and Gerardo Fortuna write.

More on Carney's visit: The Canadian PM said last night he wants a "unique alliance" with the EU, not membership, after the WSJ reported earlier Sunday that Canada was seeking "associate member" status ... and the FT says Ottawa is considering backing an EU loan for Ukraine as part of the diplomatic dalliance.

HOW TO WRITE A SOTEU: The contents of the Commission president's big set-piece speech in Strasbourg are a closely guarded secret, but Gabriel has pulled back the curtain on how it comes together in a must-click story this morning.

RATING LAST YEAR'S PLEDGES: A year after von der Leyen touted what she called the EU's "independence moment," Brussels has turbocharged its efforts on tech, defense and trade — but it remains heavily dependent on foreign partners, Gerardo reports.

LAST-MINUTE SANCTIONS PUSH: Ambassadors are keen to roll over the EU's Russia sanctions listings before they expire Tuesday, but Slovakia is pushing back on key parts — and France has now also weighed in, taking "everyone by surprise," per one diplomat. (More in Morning Trade for subscribers .)

PARTING GIFT: Donald Trump announced he'll remove the 10% U.S. tariff on Irish whiskey as he presented the Irish Open trophy at his golf resort in Doonbeg last night.

ARCTIC STRATEGY

EUROPE GOES NORTH: What are European Council President António Costa, EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas, International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela and a bunch of European leaders doing in Rovaniemi — Finland's official hometown of Santa Claus — in September?

Not getting a head start on Christmas ... but rather putting the finishing touches to the EU's Arctic strategy.

Who's there: The European Arctic Summit gets underway today, following a working dinner last night hosted by Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo. Among those attending: Germany's Friedrich Merz, Denmark's Mette Frederiksen, Romania's Nicușor Dan and leaders from the Baltics.

The High North has shot up Brussels' agenda — something Ursula von der Leyen underscored during her visit to Greenland last week. And it's not just geopolitics: Around half a million EU citizens live in the Arctic region, while security, critical raw materials, connectivity and climate are all increasingly part of the equation.

Expect a show of force: Today's program includes a visit to the Lapland Air Wing and a military demonstration while leaders are expected to commit in a statement to keeping the Arctic a region of peace and stability — while acknowledging Russia as a long-term threat to Euro-Atlantic security.

"The Arctic is on the front line of global power competition," the bloc's top diplomat Kaja Kallas told Playbook, pointing to new shipping routes and an increasingly assertive Russia and China. "We must devote sufficient funds, forces and focus to the region."

A hint is in the name: The unveiling of the Commission's revamped Arctic strategy is penciled in for Oct. 20 — but the strategy is already getting a broader label. "Northern Neighborhood" will be added to the title, reflecting Brussels' push for closer engagement with partners including Greenland, Iceland, Norway and Canada.

Speaking of partners ... The EU's goal in Rovaniemi is to get a final reality check from the countries most exposed to developments in the region before the strategy lands. Síkela told Playbook the summit

is “a unique opportunity to gather input from top European leaders” and turn the EU’s offer into “a more strategic, more focused and more visible presence in the region.”

The Arctic is expected to feature prominently in von der Leyen’s State of the Union on Wednesday, potentially offering a preview of what’s coming in October.

That could make the speech worth watching for another reason. Kallas’ team has done much of the work on the Arctic file. If Ursula unveils a big Arctic initiative from the Strasbourg stage, watch who gets the credit.

****Do you work in public affairs or lobbying? The 1st Public Affairs Summit of Spain, organised by APRI, will take place on 8 October in Madrid. Register now and join the sector’s leading gathering.****

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

On Wednesday, Ursula von der Leyen gives her State of the Union speech. But how long has this annual tradition existed? The first such speech was given in 2010 by José Manuel Barroso, with the idea being that the Commission president reviews the achievements of the past year and outlines the priorities for the forthcoming one. Von der Leyen will this week deliver her sixth State of the Union speech (there wasn’t one in 2024, the year of the last EU election).

LABOUR MOBILITY

ON THE MOVE: The Commission will tomorrow unveil the Fair Labour Mobility Package, designed to make it easier for people to work across borders while giving national authorities more tools to crack down on fraud, exploitation and bogus paperwork. The Commission will shoulder most of the up-front costs of implementing the package, with the aim of ultimately generating substantial savings for governments, workers and employers by cutting administrative burdens, an official told Zoya Sheftalovich.

Among the proposals is a skills portability initiative to make it easier to take qualifications with you across the EU. That would cut the time authorities have to assess qualifications for those in regulated professions — such as doctors, nurses, architects and civil engineers — from 120 days to 30, the Commission official said.

There’s also a new European Social Security Pass. Workers and employers could request documents such as the European Health Insurance Card and unemployment forms online, store them in the EU Digital Identity Wallet and have them verified instantly. The idea is to make life easier for the roughly 14 million EU citizens living in another member country and 2 million cross-border workers — and harder for fraudsters.

The European Labour Authority will get a stronger role coordinating cross-border inspections, helping crack down on businesses that are exploiting workers.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

GERMANY’S TOMAHAWK PLAN: Germany’s defense ministry will earmark nearly €3.4 billion to buy U.S.-made Tomahawk cruise missiles and Typhon launchers, according to an internal government

planning document seen by POLITICO.

DRUG DEAL: Germany is exploring a potential drug pricing proposal with the Trump administration in a bid to avoid new U.S. tariffs.

NEW PLENARY RULES: The European Parliament is implementing new rules for plenary sessions today with an eye to “making them more lively,” per a Parliament official — including allowing Council and Commission officials to intervene more freely and ending debates earlier.

REVIVING EUROPE’S SPIES: With Russia stepping up its campaign of hybrid sabotage and China intensifying its espionage activities, Europe’s largely dormant intelligence agencies are being given new powers to protect national interests, Antoaneta Roussi reports.

LEIPZIG SUSPECTS: German security authorities have identified a Belarusian citizen and a Russian national linked to the country’s military intelligence services as the main suspects in the failed drone attack on Leipzig-Halle airport last month, Welt reports. (Welt is owned by Axel Springer, POLITICO’s parent company.)

IT’S COMING FROM INSIDE THE HOUSE: The biggest threat to the EU is not external but comes from the domestic politics roiling Germany and France, former Belgian Prime Minister and former European Council President Herman van Rompuy said at an event in Brussels on Saturday, Seb Starcevic reports.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly overcast with some light rain. High of 23C.

TAPPED OUT: The EU is awash with environmental rules, and Belgium may finally be making some progress on the most basic green gesture of all — serving free tap water. In the interests of hydration and mild public nuisance, Zoya Sheftalovich visited 11 lunch and coffee spots in Brussels to check whether they’re getting on board.

Gold stars all around: At Exki, Le Pain Quotidien, Bouche, SUN, Mok, Cafe de la Presse, Wide Awake and LOFT, tap water was freely available — and in some cases, filtered! The canteen in the Berlaymont has filtered water, though on the day Zoya visited there were no glasses. Not to be defeated, Zoya braved the side eyes and sipped from a soup bowl.

Dry response: At Leopold, she was told it was illegal in Belgium to offer free tap water unless you need it for medical reasons. Spoiler alert: That’s not correct, but it makes for a convincing line. At ASAP, water was refused on her first visit, then begrudgingly proffered a second time after some pushing.

Bonus round for the jet-setters: Zaventem Airport has free filtered water (BYO bottle), but at Charleroi you’ll have to pay (plus it costs money to use the loo).

What the EU rules say: The EU’s Drinking Water Directive says countries should encourage restaurants and cafes to provide tap water either for free or for a low service fee. But there’s no explicit right to free water, and Belgium has not introduced rules mandating it either.

What do you think? On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked whether free tap water should be available everywhere. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

****Our AIQ experts will provide a status check on key legislation affecting regulatory stakeholders, including the Pharma Package, Critical Medicines Act and Biotech I. Sign up for the AgencyIQ webinar now.****

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz will try to show it's business as usual as he meets EU leaders at the Arctic summit in Finland , but questions about the political crisis in Berlin have followed him north.

Paris: Marine Le Pen has given Sébastien Lecornu some wiggle room on the budget as the PM looks to lay the groundwork with MPs for politically explosive pension changes.

London: Reform UK has raked in £72 million from a pair of cryptocurrency billionaires, adding rocket fuel to Labour's debate about regulating political donations.

Washington: Lawmakers are facing urgent calls to rein in AI , but time is running out before the midterms — and they're divided over what to do.

Ottawa: Mark Carney has spent the past year repeating that Canada has what the world wants — and he's about to find out if anyone's buying.

Canberra: Labor is having another crack at migration reform , but its bid to look tough on borders carries economic and diplomatic risks — and may not head off One Nation.

AGENDA

— The European Parliament begins its plenary session in Strasbourg at 5 p.m. with debates on emissions trading, the Public Procurement Act and establishing the Union Customs Code. Follow live . Last-minute press briefing at 4:30 p.m.

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen meets European Parliament President Roberta Metsola at 4:15 p.m.; and receives EPP, S&D and Renew Europe group leaders Manfred Weber, Iratxe García and Valérie Hayer. Metsola presides over the Parliament's bureau at 6 p.m.

— European Arctic Summit in Rovaniemi, Finland. Arrivals and doorsteps at 9:30 a.m. ... press conference at 1:45 p.m. with EU leaders including German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen, Council President António Costa and High Representative Kaja Kallas. Watch live .

— Informal meeting of ministers responsible for cohesion policy in Dublin. Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participates.

— Slovenian Prime Minister Janez Janša meets Metsola at 10 a.m. before meeting NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte. Press conference at 1:45 p.m.

— Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera speaks at a working meeting of the New Economy Forum in Madrid. Watch live . Meets Spanish Ecological Transition Minister Sara Aagesen and former Paris Mayor Anne Hidalgo.

— Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas meets UAE Economy and Tourism Minister Abdulla bin Touq Al Marri and representatives of Emirates.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Elissavet Vozemberg-Vrionidi; former MEPs François Alfonsi, Morten Petersen and Monika Vana; former European Commissioner Iliana Ivanova; POLITICO's Christina Gennet; NOS' Arjan Noorlander; Livia Spera, the general secretary of ETF; Deputy Chair of Russia's Security Council Dmitry Medvedev (the former PM and president); The Heritage Foundation's Paul McCarthy; European Parliament's Lucas Tripoteau; Rachel Ryan of AstraZeneca; Ron DeSantis, Florida governor.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Altana:** The rules of global trade have changed. Tariffs are tools of statecraft. Supply chains are leverage. And the old frameworks — built for a world of open markets and stable alliances — no longer hold. Policymakers need a new architecture. One that enables enforcement and trade simultaneously. One that lets governments collaborate across borders without compromising what's sovereign. Altana is that architecture. Our AI-powered network maps supply chains to the product level, verifying origin, process, and compliance before goods ever ship. Government agencies across the UK, US, Australia, and Singapore already connect through Altana to design and enforce trade and economic security policy — while businesses manage trusted trade on the same shared platform. The next era of trade won't be won by those who build the highest walls. It will be won by those who build the deepest trust. Visit altana.ai to learn how Altana can support your trade and economic security objectives .**

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